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Death of a detainee at an ICE detention center in Texas is ruled a homicide

JANUARY 22, 2026 · 4:16 PM ET

HEARD ON ALL THINGS CONSIDERED

By Angela Kocherga

4-Minute Listen

PLAYLIST

TRANSCRIPT

The El Paso County medical examiner classified the death of a 55-year-old Cuban ICE detainee as homicide.

JUANA SUMMERS, HOST:

The death of a Cuban man in a massive immigration detention camp has been ruled a homicide by the El Paso, Texas, medical examiner. Three people have died in custody in the last two months at the tent facility. It's located at Fort Bliss Army base but run by a private contractor. Angela Kocherga, with member station KTEP, joins us with more. Hi.

ANGELA KOCHERGA, BYLINE: Hi, Juana.

SUMMERS: Hi. So, Angela, give us just some of the details from the autopsy report.

KOCHERGA: Well, the autopsy shows 55-year-old Geraldo Lunas Campos died of asphyxia due to neck and torso compression. The medical examiner cited reports that said witnesses saw Lunas Campos become unresponsive while he was being restrained. And the autopsy also noted his medical history includes a bipolar disorder and anxiety, and a toxicology report shows the presence of medication used for treatment.

SUMMERS: And what has ICE said about this death as well as that medical examiner's report?

KOCHERGA: Well, the Department of Homeland Security, which oversees ICE, did not comment on the homicide ruling in an emailed response to questions today. ICE originally said Lunas Campos died while in medical distress but did not provide details and said the death was under investigation. Now, later, DHS issued a statement that said Lunas Campos tried to take his own life and, quote, "violently resisted security staff" when they intervened to save him, adding, during a struggle he stopped breathing and lost consciousness. And DHS also included information about his criminal record in the email and so did ICE when they reported the death originally.

SUMMERS: And what has the reaction been to the declaration that this was a homicide?

KOCHERGA: Well, human rights organizations have been in contact with people inside the detention camp, and they've been sounding the alarm for months about conditions, including alleged medical neglect, lack of enough food and physical abuse. Charlotte Weiss is a staff attorney with the Texas Civil Rights Project who regularly visits people detained at the camp in El Paso.

CHARLOTTE WEISS: The medical examiner's report that Geraldo's death was a homicide completely dispels the government's claim that this was a suicide. For months, the Texas Civil Rights Project and partners have reported and documented Fort Bliss' excessive use of force.

KOCHERGA: Now, the facility is at Fort Bliss, but it's run by a private contractor. It opened last August and has a capacity for up to 5,000 people. The deaths have led to more calls to shut down the place. Jenna Garcia (ph) was among those who turned out for a recent vigil for immigrants who died in custody.

JENNA GARCIA: I have just been so angry to see what they're doing, that they picked El Paso is - to build the largest detention center in the country. It's going to get bigger. More and more people are going to suffer and die, unfortunately.

KOCHERGA: ICE does have plans to expand detention space in El Paso and elsewhere across the country by building new facilities to carry out the Trump administration's mass deportation effort.

SUMMERS: And last thing, Angela, what is next as far as an investigation into the deaths of people detained at the detention camp?

KOCHERGA: Well, ICE says Lunas Campos and another man's death at the tent facility last week described as, quote, "a presumed suicide" are both under investigation. There was a third case that involved a man who died in December in a hospital where he was treated for a medical condition. That's not under investigation. DHS, in a statement today, said, quote, "ICE takes seriously the health and safety of all those detained in our custody," and that this is still an active investigation and more details are forthcoming.

Now, the federal government is trying to deport two detainees quoted in media reports, media stories, saying they witnessed Lunas Campos in an altercation with staff when he died. And lawyers for those men - one is from El Salvador, the other from Cuba - will be in federal court...

SUMMERS: OK.

KOCHERGA: ...Next week trying to extend an injunction to keep them in the country until they can give depositions.

SUMMERS: Angela Kocherga, with member station KTEP, thanks.

KOCHERGA: Thank you.

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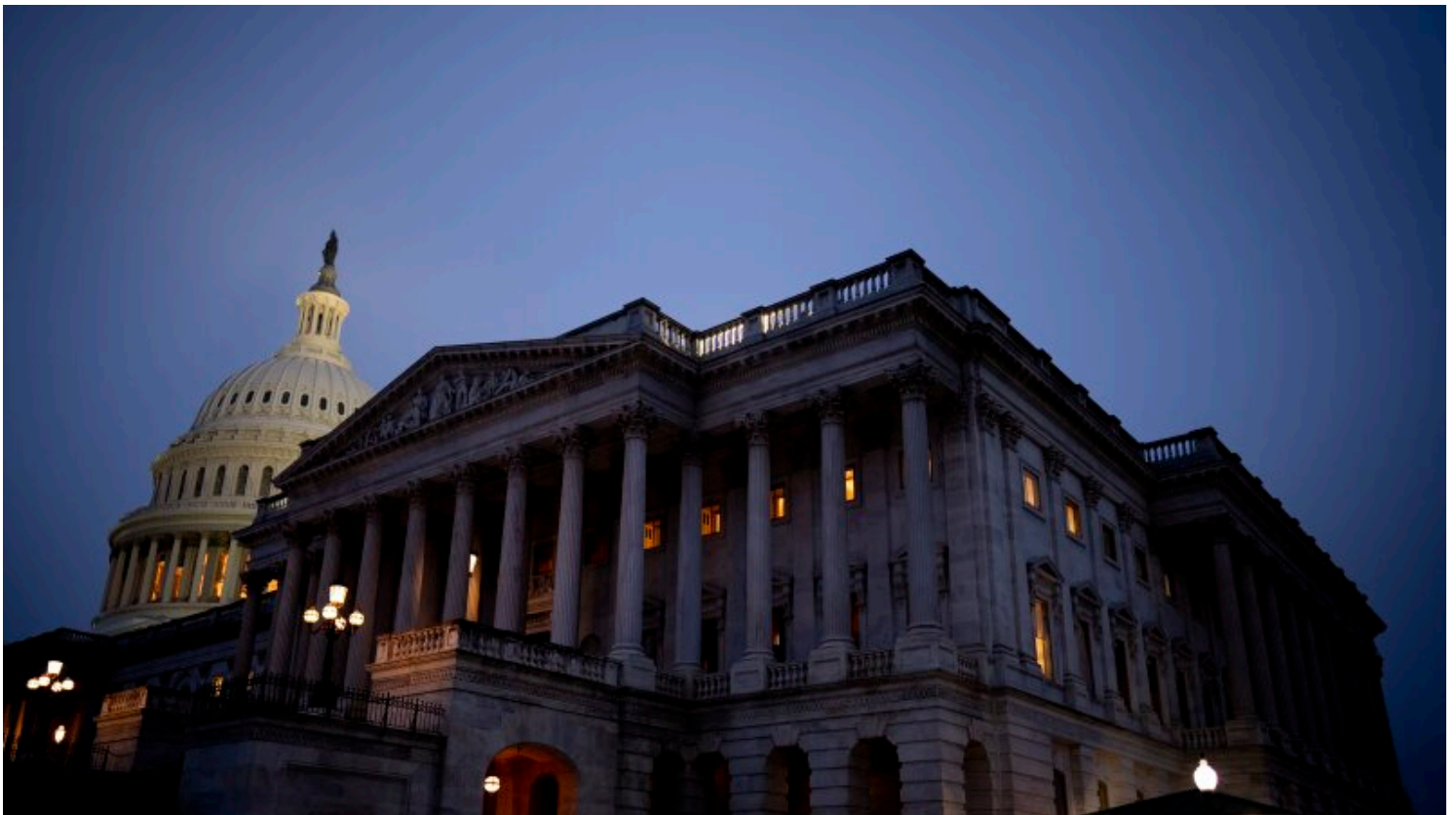
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